

biscuit packet that my sister and I had to share,” she reminisces.

Being the elder of the two siblings, the burden of responsibilities accompanied by the unflinching sense of duty was inculcated very early on in young Chitra's mind. While the breadwinner of her family moved from one place to another to educate his daughters, Chitra went on to make the most of every opportunity that came her way.

“I was the regular goody-goody first bencher and liked by all my teachers in school. I wanted to be the best in everything. I knew I had to get a job and I had to work hard to get what I wanted and make things better.”

Chitra had set her eyes on the post of a government telephone operator, by aiming for an education in Maths, Science, and Chemistry, the last being her favourite subject. While her father armed her with diligence, her mother taught her ingenuity. “In those days, it was mandatory to choose a hobby class. While other parents sent their kids to dance or music class, my mother,



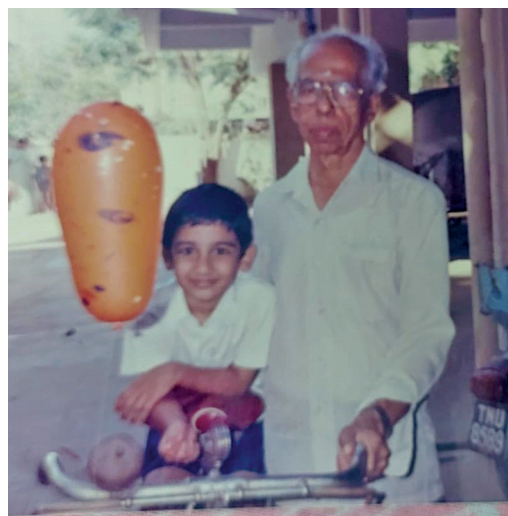
Happy family

a very enterprising lady even today, knew that for my dream job, I would need to know Hindi, so she sent me to learn a third language at the *Dakshin Bharat Hindi Prachar Sabha*.” Little did she know then that this decision would be the foundation for her to become a strong and effective communicator, skills that are paramount for a leader.

### Number one or no one

Tenacious Chitra knew that she would not be a winner unless she was at the top of the scoreboard. Later in life, she continued to give utmost importance to the academic records of all the team members she hired while building her engineering teams.

“Getting into a professional course was incredibly tough. You had to have the perfect academic record. I applied to the Government College of Technology, Coimbatore, hoping to get into one of the Applied Science courses, to secure the job of a telephone operator. With my perfect academic record and incredibly high marks, doors to the engineering course opened. In those days, we did not have any career counselling or any elders to guide us on which subject to choose. All I knew was that a professional engineering course is better



Chitra's son with his grandfather

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